Week 5: Communication Breakdown and Business Writing

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 21–25

Contents

1. Lecture 21: Communication Breakdown Part I
2. Lecture 22: Communication Breakdown Part II
3. Lecture 23: Advanced Writing Skills
4. Lecture 24: Principles of Business Writing
5. Lecture 25: Types of Business Writing Part I

Lecture 21: Communication Breakdown Part I

Week 5 · Course book PDF pages 322–339 (printed pages 321–338)

Learning objectives

- Define communication barrier or breakdown with the lecture's examples.
- Classify barriers: at the source, between people, and in the organisation.
- Explain source barriers: faltering with words, uncertain content, background, wrong inference, perception, rigid categories, frozen evaluation, allness.
- Explain interpersonal barriers: limited vocabulary, emotions, distraction, poor listening, selectivity, noise, verbal–non-verbal imbalance, semantic gap.

Important definitions

COMMUNICATION BARRIER / BREAKDOWN

Anything that blocks, restricts or interferes with the smooth flow of a message so that it fails to achieve its purpose.

HOMOPHILY

A common frame of reference between sender and receiver (two doctors, two engineers).

WRONG INFERENCE

Drawing a mistaken conclusion, like mistaking a rope for a snake at dusk.

FROZEN EVALUATION

Believing a past situation will repeat unchanged.

ALLNESS (CATEGORICAL THINKING)

Using ‘all’ and ‘every’; believing one knows everything or that everyone is against one.

COMMUNICATION SELECTIVITY

Picking out only the part of a message that interests you and ignoring the rest.

SEMANTIC GAP

A language or meaning gap caused by different uses of words.

Core concepts

Illustrative cases

- A. G. Gardiner’s *On Saying Please*: the lift man throws out a passenger who says ‘top’ without ‘please’.
- Crying baby: bottle offered, but the bed was wet.
- Train ticket: date changes after 12 midnight; passenger missed the train.
- Doctor’s ‘SOS’ misread: it means take as needed.
- E-mail to a foreign friend: too long or too short, no reply.

Three kinds of breakdown

1. At the **source** (sender).
2. **Between people** (interpersonal).
3. **In the organisation** (discussed in later lectures).

Remedy: find the cause, choose the best solution, get feedback.

Breakdown at the source

- **Faltering for words** (leave applications, in an age of channels).
- **Uncertain content** about why you are writing or speaking.
- **Different backgrounds** (a book unread by the listener); lack of homophily.
- **Wrong inferences** (rope or snake).
- **Different perceptions.**
- **Rigid categories** (‘I know nanotechnology; nothing new’).
- **Frozen evaluation** (reaching early because you missed the train once).
- **Categorical thinking / allness** (‘everyone is against me’).

“Change is the law of nature.”

Breakdown between people

- **Different perceptions of reality.**
- **Limited vocabulary** and multiple meanings (‘you are very fast’).
- **Emotional outbursts** and tiredness.
- **Distraction** from gadgets (laptop, phone, colleagues).

- **Poor listening**; noise from adjacent rooms.
- **Communication selectivity** (answering only a phrase in an interview).
- **Noise** (also used as an excuse).
- **Imbalance between verbal and non-verbal messages.**
- **Cultural differences** (Kenya: son-in-law and mother-in-law do not face each other; silence).
- **Language as code:** Mark Twain – the difference between the right word and the almost right word is that between lightning and a lightning bug.
- **Semantic gap:** 'loyal' misused for 'kind'; *sidewalk* (US), *pavement* (UK), *platform* (India); 'table a motion' – UK: bring up for discussion; US: postpone.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Barriers by origin

Level	Examples
Source	Faltering for words, unclear content, background, wrong inference, rigid categories, frozen evaluation, allness
Between people	Perception, vocabulary, emotions, distraction, poor listening, selectivity, noise, semantic gap, cultural differences
Organisation	Discussed in the next lectures (information overload and others)

Theories, principles, models and contributors

RIGHT WORD VERSUS ALMOST RIGHT WORD — MARK TWAIN

The difference is like lightning and a lightning bug.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

The lift man and 'top please'.

EXAMPLE

Rope mistaken for a snake.

EXAMPLE

Doctor's SOS tablet taken regularly.

EXAMPLE

'Table a motion' means bring it up in Britain but postpone in the US.

EXAMPLE

‘Sidewalk’ versus ‘pavement’ versus ‘platform’.

Comparison tables

British versus American usage

Word	British / Indian	American
Footpath	Pavement / platform	Sidewalk
Table a motion	Take up for discussion	Postpone

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- A. G. Gardiner’s ‘On Saying Please’.
- Three types: at the source, between people, in the organisation.
- Homophily means a common frame of reference.
- Allness uses words like all and every.
- SOS in a prescription means ‘if required’.
- Mark Twain’s lightning and lightning bug.
- ‘Table a motion’ differs in UK and US.
- Communication selectivity: hearing only what interests you.
- Rope-and-snake example of wrong inference.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q5	p.19	Semantic gap	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q6	p.19	Definition of communication breakdown	MCQ
W5 Q8	p.20	Sources of communication breakdown	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Communication breakdown occurs when something blocks the flow of a message. Barriers arise at the source (poor word choice, uncertain content, background, inference, perception, rigid thinking, frozen evaluation, allness), between people (vocabulary, emotion, distraction, poor listening, selectivity, noise, imbalance of verbal and non-verbal cues, semantic and cultural gaps) and in organisations. Awareness, feedback and careful choice of words reduce them.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) A common frame of reference between communicators is called:

A. Homophily

B. Selectivity

C. Allness

D. Noise

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Two doctors talk smoothly.

Q2 (MCQ) 'Allness' is characterised by the use of:

A. Few words

B. 'All' and 'every'

C. Silence

D. Jargon

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It is categorical thinking.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are barriers between people?

A. Communication selectivity

B. Noise

C. Poor listening

D. Clear content

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Clear content helps.

Q4 (T/F) 'Table a motion' means the same in Britain and the US.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** UK: discuss; US: postpone.

Q5 (Fill) Mistaking a rope for a snake is a wrong _____.

> **Answer:** inference
> **Why:** It is an illusion at dusk.

Q6 (Short) What is frozen evaluation?

> **Answer:** Assuming a past event will repeat in the same way regardless of changed circumstances.
> **Why:** Change is the law of nature.

Revision checklist

☐ I know three types of breakdown.
☐ I can list source barriers.
☐ I can list interpersonal barriers.
☐ I remember Gardiner and Twain.
☐ I can give semantic gap examples.

Lecture 22: Communication Breakdown Part II

Week 5 · Course book PDF pages 340–353 (printed pages 339–352)

Learning objectives

- List the barriers to communication in organisations.
- Explain transfer stations, media richness, jargon, physical distractions, ethics and misquoting.
- Apply the remedies: non-judgmental language, empathy, listening, audience-centred messages, open climate, fewer levels, feedback.
- Recall the lecture's examples and Whitman's quotation.

Important definitions

TRANSFER STATION

An intermediate level through which a message passes in a hierarchy; at each station the message may be reframed and distorted.

MEDIA RICHNESS

The variety of channels available; the lecture stresses choosing the channel suited to the receiver's background and facilities.

LEAN MEDIA

Channels or messages for technical and objective information, which people often attend to least.

PROPER CHANNEL

Following the prescribed route of reporting rather than approaching the top directly.

MISQUOTING

Reporting what another said inaccurately; an ethical lapse.

AUDIENCE-CENTRED APPROACH

Viewing the message from the receiver's point of view ('you' attitude).

Core concepts

Organisational barriers

- **Organisational structure:** tall hierarchy, many units; 'proper channel' restricts upward communication.
- **Fear of superior's perception** – juniors withhold information.

- **Negative attitudes** of employees and managers destroy candour.
- **Status gap** between senior and junior; lack of trust; grapevine functions as a ‘purgatory force’ (release).
- **Poor communication skills** make peers avoid talking.
- **Groups and subgroups** based on religion, faith, interest threaten channels.
- **Too many transfer stations** distort messages: ‘the message sent is not always the message received’ (example: ‘a friend is passing away’ became ‘he is no more’).
- **Wrong choice of media**, ignoring the receiver’s facilities; **information overload**.
- **Technical jargon** used with non-experts.
- **Physical distractions:** noise, poor acoustics, lighting, climate, power cuts, venue.
- **Ethical issues:** misquotes, far-fetched predictions, rumours that go viral.

Overcoming the barriers

- Be **non-judgmental**; select words carefully so they are not open to another meaning.
- **Put yourself in the other’s shoes**; be empathetic; avoid unnecessary assumptions.
- Be a **good listener**.
- Avoid jargon; keep sentences and paragraphs short; consider cultural bias.
- Keep non-verbal behaviour consistent with words.
- Adopt an **audience-centred** approach.
- Create an **open communication climate**.
- **Reduce the number of levels**; use direct communication when important.
- Seek **immediate feedback**.
- Commit to ethical communication; avoid extreme statements; create lean, efficient messages.
- Select the most suitable medium for the audience background.

The assumption story

A woman waiting at a bus stop smiled at a man's baby; he asked “Are you waiting for me?” — a wrong assumption. She replied that she had a baby at home. People misconstrue messages because they do not understand others’ assumptions and perceptions.

Walt Whitman (“Song of Myself”): “I celebrate myself, and sing myself, and what I assume you shall assume, for every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.”

Types, classifications and characteristics

Organisational barriers and remedies

Barrier	Remedy
Fear of superior	Open communication climate
Negative attitude	Empathy, non-judgmental language
Transfer stations	Reduce levels; direct communication
Wrong media / overload	Choose suitable medium; lean messages
Jargon	Plain language; short sentences
Physical noise	Suitable venue, acoustics, lighting
Misquoting / rumours	Ethical communication

Theories, principles, models and contributors

SONG OF MYSELF — WALT WHITMAN (AMERICAN POET QUOTED)

“What I assume you shall assume” — think of how the message would affect you as receiver.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

‘A friend is passing away’ transmitted as ‘he is no more’.

EXAMPLE

A woman and a man with a baby at the bus stop.

EXAMPLE

Tall hierarchy forces use of proper channel.

EXAMPLE

Newly recruited managers require plain words; senior peers may use jargon.

Comparison tables

Closed versus open communication climate

Closed / restrictive	Open
Fear of superiors	Candid exchange
Many transfer stations	Direct and fewer levels
Distrust, grapevine	Trust and business thrives

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- The message sent is not always the message received.
- Too many transfer stations distort messages.
- Media richness: choose the channel suited to the receiver.
- Reduce levels and encourage direct communication.
- Take immediate feedback.
- Whitman: what I assume you shall assume.
- Grapevine acts as a purgatory force.
- Use of jargon with non-experts is a barrier.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q1	p.19	Causes of communication breakdown	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q3	p.19	Ethical breakdown	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q8	p.20	Sources of communication breakdown	MCQ
W5 Q11	p.20	Organisational barriers	MSQ
W5 Q14	p.21	Ethics in communication	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Organisational barriers include tall hierarchies, fear of superiors, negative attitudes, mistrust, subgroups, many transfer stations, wrong media, information overload, jargon, physical distractions and unethical practices such as misquoting. They are overcome by empathy, careful words, active listening, audience-centred messages, an open climate, fewer levels, suitable media and prompt feedback.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) A message passing through many levels may be distorted because of:

A. Transfer stations

B. Homophily

C. Feedback

D. Media richness

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Each station reframes the message.

Q2 (MCQ) 'Proper channel' in an organisation refers to:

A. Following the prescribed reporting route

B. Using social media

C. Anonymous letters

D. Grapevine

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** You cannot approach the top directly.

Q3 (MSQ) Which help overcome organisational barriers?

A. Immediate feedback

B. Fewer levels

C. Heavy jargon

D. Audience-centred messages

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Jargon is a barrier.

Q4 (T/F) Grapevine is always harmful, according to the lecture.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It can act as a purgatory (releasing) force.

Q5 (Fill) A message sent is not always the message _____.

> **Answer:** received
> **Why:** Because of distortion.

Q6 (Short) Why does fear of the superior hinder communication?

> **Answer:** Juniors hold back ideas and information under the weight of the superior's post, so candour is lost.
> **Why:** An open climate is the remedy.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list organisational barriers.
☐ I understand transfer stations.
☐ I can list remedies.
☐ I remember the passing-away story.
☐ I can quote Whitman.

Lecture 23: Advanced Writing Skills

Week 5 · Course book PDF pages 354–375 (printed pages 353–374)

Learning objectives

- Explain why writing matters and the features of advanced writing (conceptualise, research, draft, revise, reader-centred).
- Differentiate informative and persuasive writing.
- Apply directness, simple words and short sentences, and outlining.
- List the nine writing patterns with examples.

Important definitions

ADVANCED WRITING

Professional, technical and scientific writing (proposals, reports, technical descriptions, business letters) based on a concept, research, drafting and revision, and centred on the reader.

READER-CENTRED WRITING

Writing planned from the reader's point of view; it uses the 'you' tone.

INFORMATIVE WRITING

Writing that conveys information as it is (e.g. stock verification form).

PERSUASIVE / ARGUMENTATIVE WRITING

Writing that explains, contradicts, counters arguments and convinces, with an assertive tone (thesis, dissertation).

OUTLINE

A tentative plan with main topics, sub-topics and supporting points, like the tailor's cutting plan.

DIRECTNESS

Expressing the point plainly, without circumlocution.

Core concepts

Why writing matters

- Francis Bacon: **"Reading maketh a full man, conference a ready man, and writing an exact man."**
- Reveals personality, grasp of language and reasoning in your absence.
- Serves as a **record** (now through word processing and databases).

- Professional work needs proposals, reports, manuals, technical descriptions and letters (credit, collection, complaint, adjustment).

Stages of advanced writing

1. **Conceptualise** – have an idea; testify with truth and objectivity.
2. **Research** – books and papers to support the concept.
3. **Draft** – structure suited to report, letter, proposal or description.
4. **Revise** – add, delete, check against the audience.
5. Check that the writing is **reader-centric**.

Ask first: **Why** am I writing and for **whom**? Aims: express, inform, convince, persuade.

Style rules

- **Directness** – plain, candid language, no circumlocution.
- Short sentences (6–8 words are simple; 20–30 words are hard).
- Familiar words; avoid jargon with lay readers; avoid pompous or wordy language; do not sacrifice meaning for brevity.
- Make an outline; ensure unity, coherence and logic.
- Put the verb early: "Please submit the report to me no later than 5 p.m. tomorrow" (better than "You will do me a personal favour…").
- Keep SVA (subject–verb agreement) and active voice; use 'you' tone.
- **Alexander Pope:** "True ease in writing comes from art, not chance, as those move easiest who have learned to dance."

Nine writing patterns

1. **Direct plan** – good or routine news first: "Congratulations! Your proposal…".
2. **Indirect plan** – bad news: buffer, reasons, negative in the middle, positive ending (job-rejection example).
3. **Order of importance** – most important reason first (recommendation letter).
4. **Chronology** – time sequence (resume, incident report).
5. **Problem–solution.**
6. **Causal** – cause to effect or the reverse (Pali losing speakers).
7. **Spatial** – by geography (sales north, south, east, west).
8. **Structural** – by parts or structure (bonus, hike, compensation; course objective).
9. **Topical** – breaks topics into subtopics.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Nine patterns of writing

Pattern	Use
Direct plan	Good or routine news
Indirect plan	Bad or unpleasant news
Order of importance	Recommendations; ranked reasons
Chronology	Resume, incident report
Problem–solution	Proposals
Causal	Cause–effect analysis
Spatial	Geographical description
Structural	Parts of a plan or course
Topical	Subtopics

Theories, principles, models and contributors

WRITING MAKES AN EXACT MAN — FRANCIS BACON

Called the father of the essay; his essays are aphoristic.

EASE IN WRITING — ALEXANDER POPE

Art, not chance, produces ease.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

“Congratulations! Your proposal for the workshop has evoked interest.” (direct)

EXAMPLE

“Thank you for your application... Because of our size and reputation we review...” (indirect rejection)

EXAMPLE

Resume year by year (chronology).

EXAMPLE

“Pali is losing 60% significance because of fewer users.” (causal)

Comparison tables

Informative versus persuasive writing

Point	Informative	Persuasive
Purpose	Convey facts as they are	Convince, counter arguments
Tone	Neutral	Assertive, argumentative
Example	Stock verification form	Thesis, dissertation

Direct versus indirect plan

Direct	Indirect
Main point first	Buffer first, bad news later
Good/routine news	Unpleasant news
Pleasant tone	Guarded with positive ending

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Bacon: writing maketh an exact man.
- Stages: conceptualise, research, draft, revise.
- Ask why and for whom.
- Nine patterns: direct, indirect, order of importance, chronology, problem–solution, causal, spatial, structural, topical.
- Bad news goes in the indirect plan with a positive ending.
- Short sentences of 6–8 words are simple.
- Pope: true ease in writing comes from art, not chance.
- Writing serves as a record.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q2	p.19	Goal of business writing	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q4	p.19	Direct and indirect plans in writing	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q9	p.20	Patterns of organising writing	MCQ
W5 Q12	p.21	Features of effective writing	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Advanced writing is concept-based, researched, drafted, revised and reader-centred. It should be direct, simple and short-sentenced, planned with an outline. Informative writing reports facts; persuasive writing argues. Choose among nine patterns – direct, indirect, order of importance, chronology, problem–solution, causal, spatial, structural, topical – and put bad news in the indirect plan with a positive close.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) 'Writing maketh an exact man' is by:

A. Alexander Pope

B. Francis Bacon

C. Mark Twain

D. Freud

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** From Bacon's essay on studies.

Q2 (MCQ) Which plan is suited to unpleasant news?

A. Direct

B. Indirect

C. Chronological

D. Spatial

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Buffer, explain, close positively.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are among the nine patterns?

A. Causal

B. Spatial

C. Topical

D. Emotional

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Emotional is not a pattern.

Q4 (T/F) A resume is best organised chronologically.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Year-wise listing.

Q5 (Fill) Before writing, ask why you are writing and for _____.

> **Answer:** whom
> **Why:** Reader-centred writing.

Q6 Short List the stages of advanced writing.

> **Answer:** Conceptualise, research, draft, revise and check for reader-centricity.
> **Why:** Make an outline too.

Revision checklist

☐ I can recall Bacon and Pope.
☐ I know the stages of writing.
☐ I can distinguish informative and persuasive writing.
☐ I can list the nine patterns.
☐ I can rewrite sentences with the verb first.

Lecture 24: Principles of Business Writing

Week 5 · Course book PDF pages 376–392 (printed pages 375–391)

Learning objectives

- List the 5 Cs of business writing: clarity, courtesy, consideration, conciseness, cordiality.
- Explain how to achieve clarity, conciseness, courtesy and consideration with before-and-after examples.
- Recall the quotations of T. S. Eliot and Oscar Wilde and the maxim ‘express, not impress’.
- Rewrite negative and wordy sentences using the you-attitude.

Important definitions

CLARITY

Writing that is unambiguous, plain and easily understood so that action can follow.

COURTESY

Respect shown to the reader in tone and word choice, even when information is dry.

CONSIDERATION

Writing from the reader’s viewpoint (the ‘you’ approach), so no one is hurt.

CONCISENESS

Being brief without sacrificing meaning; removing redundant words and flabby phrases.

CORDIALITY

Warmth and goodwill sustained in writing, since business is dealing with people.

FOGGY WRITING

Unclear, cloudy messages produced by unskilled writers who have not learnt to communicate clearly.

Core concepts

The 5 Cs

1. **Clarity** – ambiguity is an unwelcome guest in business.
2. **Courtesy**
3. **Consideration**
4. **Conciseness**

5. **Cordiality**

Goal: **express, not impress**; impress through simplicity and clarity.

Clarity

- Unskilled writers produce foggy messages; use familiar words.
- Example: "Employees have not been made sufficiently aware of the potentially adverse consequences…" → **"Warn your employees about these chemicals."**
- It is better to use a few more words than fewer words that are difficult.
- **T. S. Eliot:** "Do not use big words too big for the subject; do not say 'infinitely' when you mean 'very'."

Conciseness: shorter expressions

- a number of → **many**
- at your earliest possible convenience → **soon**
- fullest possible extent → **fully**
- it would be unreasonable to assume → **I assume**
- "There are three things I want you to do" → "I want you to do three things."
- Remove needless repetitions and redundant phrases; avoid excessive noun habit and pompous words; revise last. "Brevity is the soul of wit."

Courtesy and consideration: rewriting

- "You cannot meet the director; don't you know he is out of station?" → "Thanks for your interest; today he is out of station. We will call you when he returns."
- "Will you send me 125 geysers at the official rate?" → "We require 125 geysers and expect to buy at the official rate."
- "The executive meeting is postponed." → "We regret the inconvenience; the meeting has been postponed for unavoidable reasons."
- "You must know that PAN alone can make online tax procedure easy." → "We would appreciate your PAN number; it will make tax procedure smoother."
- "Your project is returned; no more funds this year." → "Thanks for submitting; we regret we lack funds this year, but will let you know once funds are available."
- Complaint about ACs: "We have received several complaints about the ACs supplied by us; we look forward to knowing what can be done." (you-attitude)
- Put the negative in the middle and end positively; give hope.

Cordiality

- Avoid negative starts: "You are not a member, we cannot entertain you" → "We entertain our members; we expect you to join."
- "Your report is unsatisfactory" → "We appreciate a detailed report."
- "You should not ignore the official instructions" → "All of us follow the official timing: reports are due Friday."
- **Oscar Wilde:** "If you pretend to be good, the world takes you very seriously." Keep hope alive, since a bad deal with a customer can cost an organisation heavily.

Types, classifications and characteristics

The 5 Cs

C	Meaning	Tip
Clarity	Unambiguous message	Use familiar words
Courtesy	Respect for reader	Polite tone
Consideration	Reader's viewpoint	You-attitude
Conciseness	Brief but complete	Cut redundancy
Cordiality	Warm goodwill	Positive framing

Theories, principles, models and contributors

BIG WORDS — T. S. ELIOT

"Do not use big words too big for the subject."

PRETENDING TO BE GOOD — OSCAR WILDE

Quoted to encourage optimism in writing.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

"Warn your employees about these chemicals."

EXAMPLE

"We grew hot and cold" (flowery) → "We have received complaints about the ACs."

EXAMPLE

Rejecting a project politely with hope.

EXAMPLE

"Many" replaces "a number of".

Comparison tables

Wordy versus concise

Wordy	Concise
A number of	Many
At your earliest possible convenience	Soon
Fullest possible extent	Fully
It would be unreasonable to assume	I assume
There are three things I want you to do	I want you to do three things

Express versus impress

Express	Impress
Make the reader understand	Show off difficult words
Goal of business writing	Not the goal

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- 5 Cs: clarity, courtesy, consideration, conciseness, cordiality.
- Goal of business writing: to express, not to impress.
- Eliot: do not use big words; do not say infinitely for very.
- Put negative news in the middle and end positively.
- Brevity is the soul of wit.
- Revision is the last task in writing.
- Wilde quote on pretending to be good.
- ‘Warn your employees about these chemicals’ example.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q10	p.20	Stages of the writing process	Ordering (MCQ)
W5 Q15	p.21	Principles of business writing	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Good business writing follows the 5 Cs. Express rather than impress: use plain, familiar words, cut redundant phrases and avoid foggy sentences. Show courtesy and consideration by taking the reader’s

viewpoint, soften negatives, put bad news in the middle and end with hope, and keep cordiality so that relationships and business continue.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) The goal of business writing is to:

A. Impress

B. Express

C. Confuse

D. Entertain

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Clarity over show.

Q2 (MCQ) 'At your earliest possible convenience' can be replaced by:

A. Soon

B. Never

C. Someday

D. Quickly please

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Shorter and clear.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are among the 5 Cs?

A. Clarity

B. Courtesy

C. Criticism

D. Cordiality

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Criticism is not a C.

Q4 (T/F) Eliot advised using the biggest words available.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** He advised against big words.

Q5 (Fill) Put negative news in the _____ and end positively.

> **Answer:** middle
> **Why:** Indirect plan.

Q6 Short How do you make a complaint letter considerate?

> **Answer:** State the facts politely from the receiver's viewpoint and ask what can be done, avoiding anger.
> **Why:** Use the you-attitude.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list the 5 Cs.
☐ I know the concise replacements.
☐ I can rewrite rude sentences politely.
☐ I remember Eliot and Wilde.
☐ I know express vs impress.

Lecture 25: Types of Business Writing Part I

Week 5 · Course book PDF pages 393–410 (printed pages 392–409)

Learning objectives

- List the types of business writing: letters, reports, memos, letter reports, circulars, e-mails, technical proposals, research papers.
- Define a memo, state its purposes, tone and format.
- Differentiate memo, memo report, letter report and circular.
- Describe the types of circulars.

Important definitions

MEMO (INTER-OFFICE MEMORANDUM)

A short, informal piece of business writing circulated within an organisation to confirm, suggest, inform, explain, announce, report or warn.

MEMO REPORT

A memo written in report form for a longer explanation.

LETTER REPORT

A report written in business-letter format; less informal than a memo, longer (about 2–3 pages), may go inside or outside the organisation, with an inside address, salutation and complimentary close.

CIRCULAR

A document circulated within (or sometimes outside) an organisation to inform, create awareness or announce policy, products or programmes.

CC (CARBON COPY)

A line at the end on the left, listing persons who receive a copy.

Core concepts

Types of business writing

- Business letters (sell, buy, order, remind)
- Reports
- Memos
- Letter reports
- Circulars

- Electronic mails
- Technical proposals
- Research papers

Follow the standards and practices of your organisation.

Purposes of a memo

- **Confirm** (meeting outcomes)
- **Suggest** action
- **Inform / explain** (why something went wrong)
- **Announce** policies, hikes, DA, products
- **Request / report** information
- **Warn** (late coming, misuse of photocopier) without offending, because the tone is informal

A memo is not always a threat.

Format of a memo

- **Letterhead** (organisation name) at the top centre.
- **To** and **From** on the left; From shows the **designation**, not the name.
- **Reference number and date** on the right.
- **Subject line** in the middle, explicit.
- **No salutation and no complimentary close**; direct, short, specific, conversational, informal.
- Body: problem → explanation → action required.
- Writer's name at the end (right); **cc** on the left.

Sample memo: from Dean (Admission) to all heads about dissatisfactory campus placement; proposes faculty development training and meeting heads; cc Dean Academics.

Letter report

- Letterhead, date, inside address, subject, formal salutation ('Dear Sir'), introduction, findings, complimentary close, signature, enclosures (with number of pages).
- Longer than a memo (1 page memo, 2–3 pages letter report); includes discussion and illustrations; less formal than a full formal report.
- Example: report on a faculty development programme.

Circular

- Purpose: inform, create awareness, matters of general interest.
- Use a memo for people within the organisation; use a circular for larger audiences including outside.
- Structure: introduction, details, relevant information; short unless required.
- Letterhead on top centre, 'Circular', content, signature.
- Revise carefully for spelling and grammar because reputation is at stake.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Types of circulars

Type	Audience / purpose
Informative circular	Factual; introduction, details, relevant information
Public circular	General awareness to large, spread-out audiences (e.g. child labour policy)
Partnership / company circular	Partners, shareholders and stakeholders
Official circular	Wide audience in organisations; longer and carefully worded

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Dean (Admission) memo on placements and faculty development.

EXAMPLE

Letter report on faculty development training.

EXAMPLE

Warning memo about misuse of the photocopier.

Comparison tables

Memo versus letter report versus circular

Point	Memo	Letter report	Circular
Audience	Within organisation	Inside or outside	Within; sometimes public
Tone	Informal	Less informal	Informal yet formal
Length	Short (about one page)	2–3 pages	Short unless needed
Salutation / close	None	Yes	None
Address	To / From	Inside address	Letterhead

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Memo = inter-office memorandum.
- A memo has no salutation or complimentary close.
- From line shows designation.
- Reference number and date on the right.
- cc line at the end left.
- Letter report may have 2–3 pages and enclosures.
- Four circular types: informative, public, partnership/company, official.
- Memo purposes: confirm, suggest, inform, explain, announce, report, warn.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q2	p.19	Goal of business writing	Fill-in-the-blank
W5 Q13	p.21	Internal business documents	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Business writing includes letters, reports, memos, letter reports, circulars, e-mails, proposals and research papers. A memo is a short, informal intra-office document with letterhead, To/From (designation), reference and date, subject line and body but no salutation or close. A letter report is a longer, letter-format report that may go outside; a circular informs larger audiences and has four types.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) A memo does NOT contain:

A. Subject line

B. Salutation

C. Date

D. Reference number

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** No salutation or complimentary close.

Q2 (MCQ) In a memo, the 'From' line shows:

A. Name only

B. Designation

C. Address

D. Phone number

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Designation is written, not name.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are types of circulars?

A. Informative

B. Public

C. Official

D. Private diary

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Partnership/company is also a type.

Q4 (T/F) A letter report is always shorter than a memo.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It is longer (2–3 pages).

Q5 (Fill) A memo is also called an _____ memorandum.

> **Answer:** inter-office
> **Why:** It circulates within the organisation.

Q6 (Short) State two purposes of a memo.

> **Answer:** To confirm a meeting outcome and to announce a policy (also suggest, explain, report, warn).
> **Why:** Tone remains informal.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list types of business writing.

☐ I know memo format.

☐ I can compare memo, letter report and circular.

☐ I know four circular types.

☐ I know memo purposes.